

THE UNIVERSITY *of* EDINBURGH

Statistical Case Studies

Statistical Case Studies – Project 1 (Part 1)

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Word Count: XXXX

October 2026

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1 Executive Summary

Current flood risk models generally assume that the shape of a flood is fixed, varying only in its maximum river flow. This project investigates whether this approach captures the uncertainty in flood events on the River Don at Parkhill, by considering both the maximum flow and the time a flood takes to reach its peak.

Using ten years of river discharge data, we identified 44 independent extreme flow events, across which both quantities varied considerably, with median values of around 106 m^3/s and 44 hours respectively. Flood events were concentrated in autumn and winter, with autumn events typically taking longer to reach their peak, and we found only weak evidence of a relationship between maximum flow and time to peak, suggesting that larger floods do not necessarily develop more slowly.

These findings suggest that assuming a fixed hydrograph shape may overlook important uncertainty, so SEPA should consider incorporating variation in time to peak alongside maximum flow in future flood risk modelling guidance.

2 Data and Exploratory Analysis

2.1 Data Description and Quality

Table 1: Data used in this analysis, and the quality codes assigned to each reading

Data description	
Station	Don at Parkhill
Source	SEPA time series data service
Measurement	River discharge (m^3/s)
Resolution	15 minutes
Period	01 October 2016 – 30 September 2026
Readings	350,592
Missing readings	0
Quality codes	
50 – Good (G)	335,515 readings (95.70%), retained
100 – Estimated (E)	14,915 readings (4.25%), retained
140 – Provisional (Prov)	0 readings (0.00%), excluded
150 – Suspect (S)	0 readings (0.00%), excluded
200 – Unchecked (imported from legacy database) (V)	0 readings (0.00%), excluded
254 – Unchecked (U)	162 readings (0.05%), excluded

The subsequent analysis uses 350,592 discharge readings (m^3/s) from the River Don at Parkhill velocity-area gauging station, recorded every 15-minutes between 1 October 2016 and 30 September 2026, covering 10 water years. Parkhill, the lowest gauging station on the Don, has a catchment area of 1,273 km^2 and applies a single peak flow rating curve to all measurements.

The dataset is complete, with each reading assigned a SEPA quality code (Table 1).

- Estimated ($n = 14,915$): Retained. SEPA defines these as acceptable rating curve extrapolations where the river level exceeds the 3.7 m gauging limit, at which Good readings are capped (Figure 1), so they contain the largest flows and preserve the extremes.
- Unchecked ($n = 162$): Excluded. These are restricted to recent entries (29 September 2026, 16:15 onward) and in sporadic 2017–2018 bursts of at most 45 minutes, and only

two coincided with extreme flows, so removing them leaves a fully verified dataset with negligible impact.

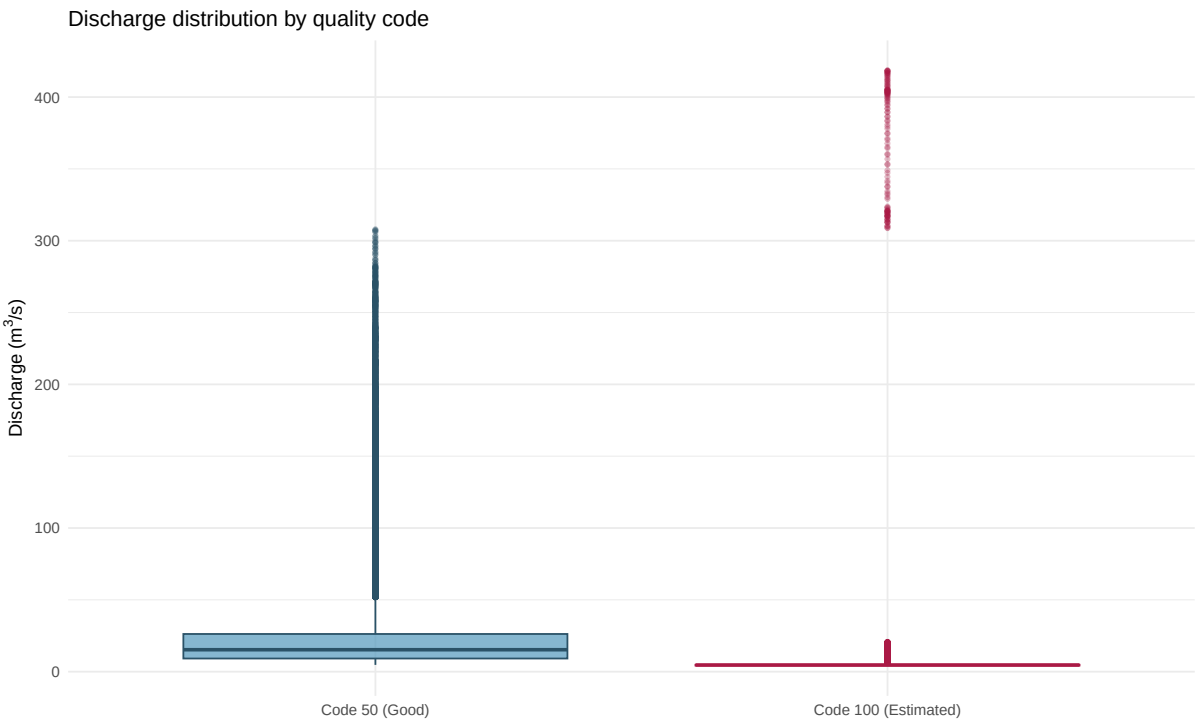


Figure 1: Discharge distribution for quality codes 50 & 100.

2.2 Exploratory Analysis

2.2.1 Hydrograph and Distribution

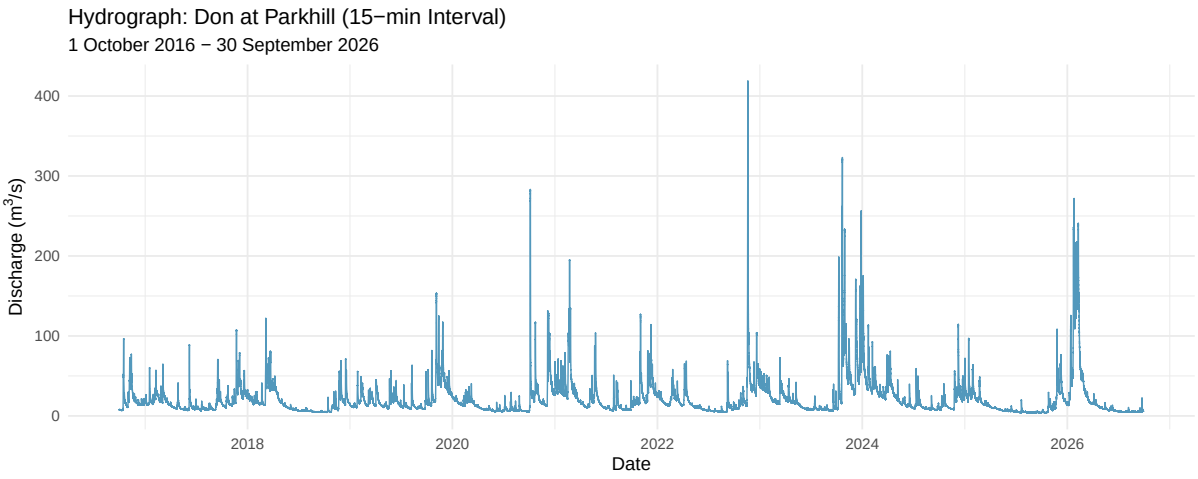
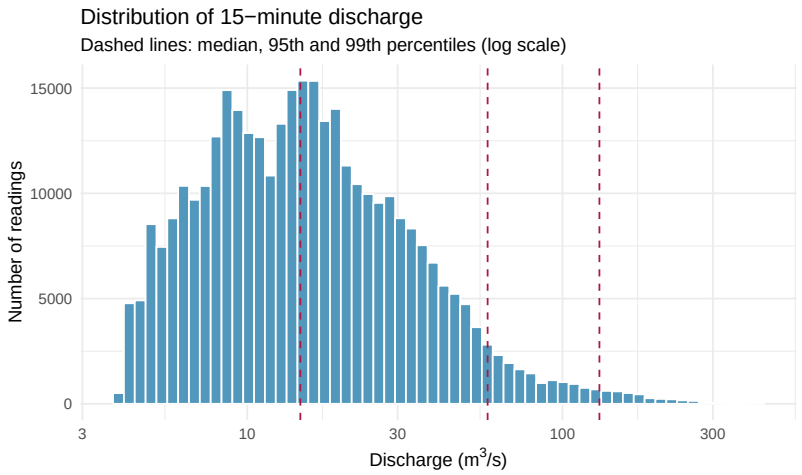


Figure 2: Hydrograph of 15-minute discharge for the Don at Parkhill.



Statistic	Value (m³/s)
Mean	21.65
Standard deviation	24.38
Minimum	3.90
25th percentile	8.74
Median	14.73
75th percentile	25.44
95th percentile	57.88
99th percentile	130.97
Maximum	418.68

Figure 3: Distribution of 15-minute discharge on a log scale, with summary statistics. Dashed lines mark the median, 95th and 99th percentiles.

From Figure 2 shows that discharge is low for most of the year, with a small number of large peaks, the largest reaching 418.68 m^3/s on 19 November 2022. The distribution is strongly right-skewed (Figure 3), with a median of 14.73 m^3/s against a 99th percentile of 130.97 m^3/s, suggesting that extreme flows behave very differently from typical flows and need to be analysed separately.

2.2.2 Seasonality of High Flows

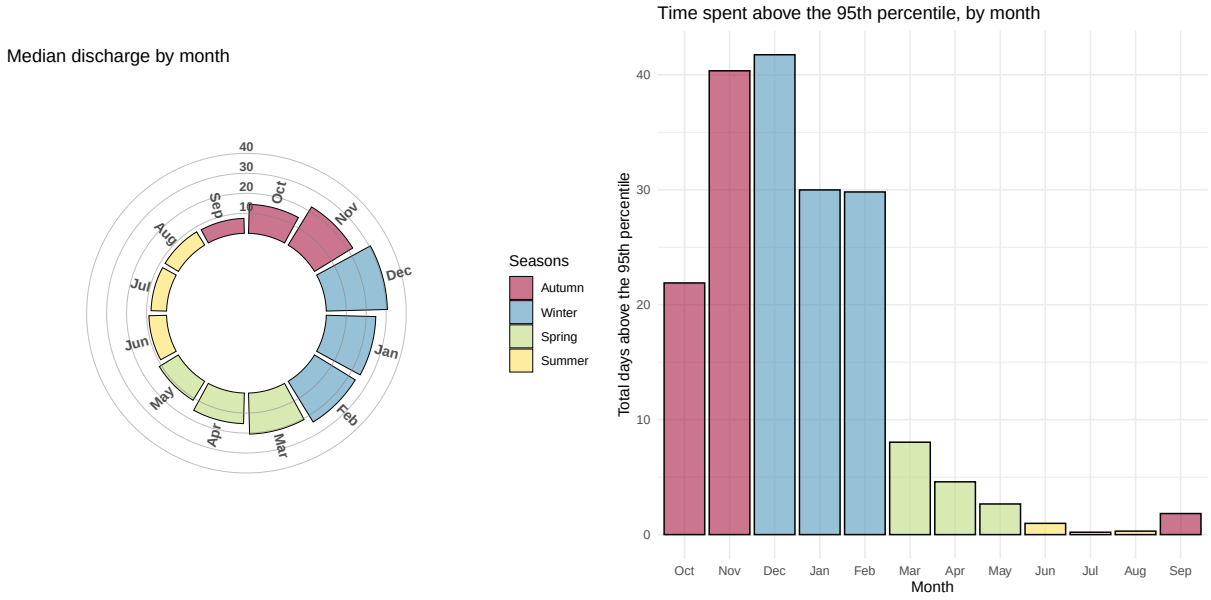


Figure 4: Median discharge by month (left) and total days spent above the 95th percentile in each month (right).

Median discharge is highest from December to February and lowest from July to September, while time spent above the 95th percentile is concentrated even more tightly to between October and February (Figure 3).

2.2.3 Flood Event Hydrographs

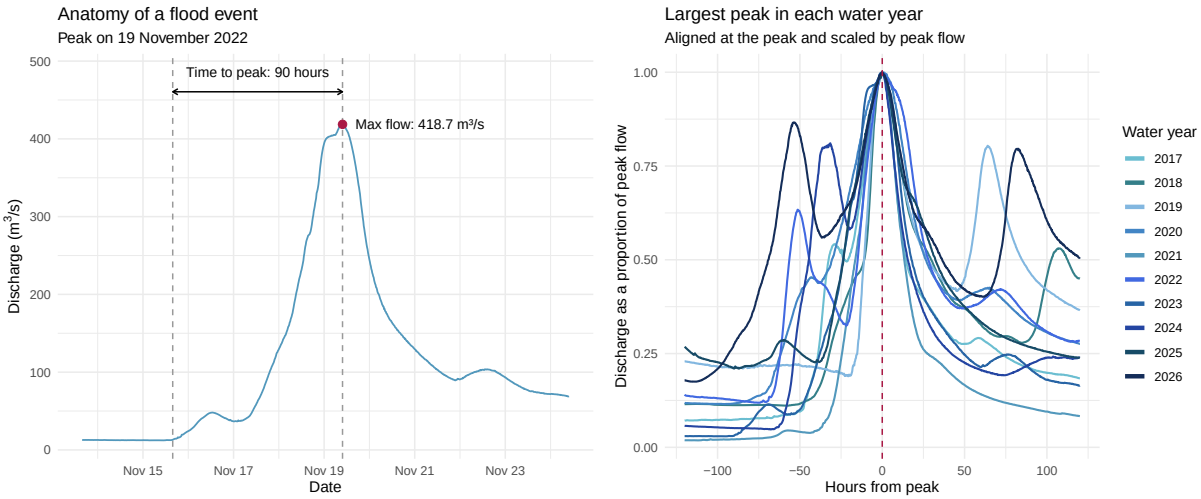


Figure 5: The largest recorded flood event, showing the max flow and time to peak (left), and the largest peak in each water year, aligned at the peak and scaled by peak flow (right).

This introduces a key assumption that we will use throughout the report:

- Start of the rise: the last reading before the peak with flow at most $q_{\min} + 0.05\,(q_{\text{peak}} - q_{\min})$, where $q_{\min}$ is the lowest flow in the previous 7 days.

Figure 4 shows the maximum flow and time to peak for the largest observed event, and that the largest peak in each water year varies considerably in shape, so treating the hydrograph shape as fixed ignores an important source of uncertainty. Smaller peaks also cluster around each largest peak, so independent events must be separated.

3 Threshold Selection and Independence

3.1 Initial Threshold

The previous section confirmed the need to extract high flows, and to do so we use the Peaks Over Threshold (POT). This extracts flood events as the peaks of flow above a threshold u, and two common rules for choosing u are the 95th percentile of flow and a threshold giving 3 to 5 peaks per year. Figure 6 shows both on the hydrograph, where the 95th percentile is 57.9 m^3/s, and counting each period above the threshold as a peak gives at least 5, 4 and 3 peaks per year at 79, 93 and 113 m^3/s. At this stage, however, a single flood can cross the threshold several times, so these counts overstate the number of distinct events. Robson and Reed (1999) note that a threshold giving around five peaks a year leaves the flexibility to raise it later to exclude smaller floods, and the lecture notes that the threshold may need to change once independence has been applied. Since the 95th percentile gives 9.4, well above this range, we take the threshold giving 5 peaks per year $u = 79\ m^3/s$, as our initial threshold.

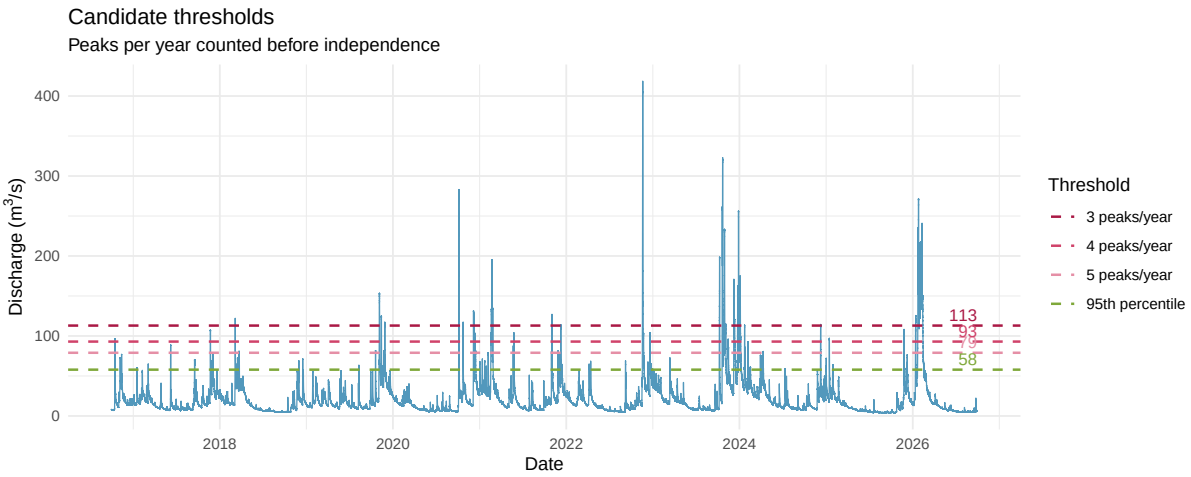


Figure 6: Hydrograph with the candidate thresholds. Peaks per year are counted before applying the independence rules.

3.2 Independence of Peaks

To make sure each peak represents a separate flood, we apply the independence rules of Robson and Reed (1999). Two adjacent peaks are only treated as separate events if:

1. they are at least three times the average time to rise apart, where the time to rise is the time between a trough and its peak, averaged over at least five clean peaks above the threshold; and
2. the flow at the trough between them is at least two-thirds lower than the first peak, i.e. below a third of it.

If either rule fails, we treat the peaks as one event and keep the larger peak. In applying these rules, we use the following assumptions:

- Clean peak: a peak with no other candidate peak in the previous 7 days.
- Trough: the start of the rise defined in the exploratory analysis, which we use to calculate the time to rise.

At the initial threshold, the average time to rise is 57.2 hours, so peaks must be at least 171.6 hours apart. This reduces the 56 candidate peaks to 35 independent events, or 3.5 per year (Figure 7).

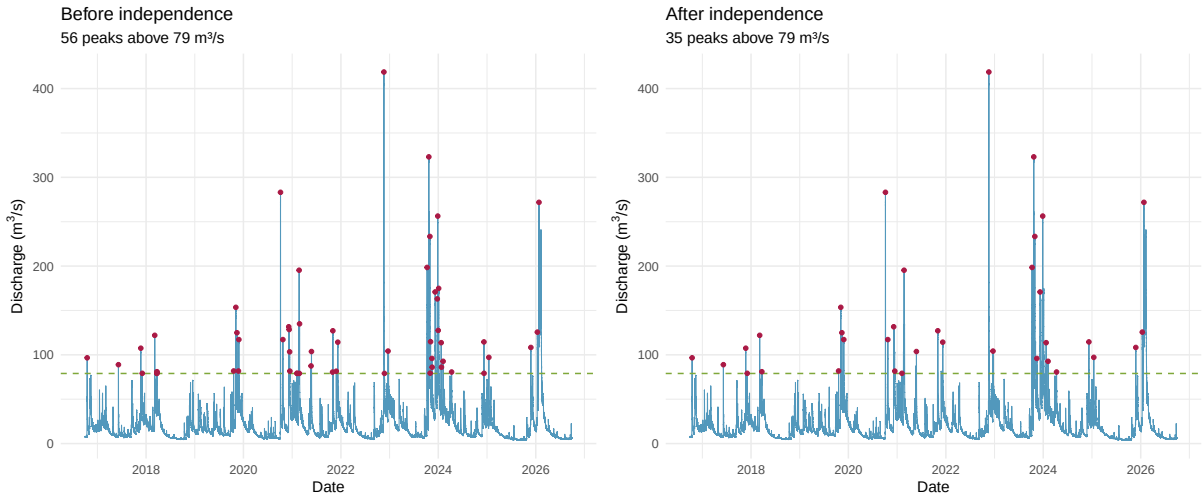


Figure 7: Peaks above the initial threshold before (left) and after (right) applying the independence rules.

3.3 Final Threshold

Since separating events lowers the number of peaks per year, we recheck the threshold using independent peaks only. Our initial threshold gives 3.5 independent peaks per year, while Figure 8 shows that thresholds between 57 and 81 m^3/s give 3 to 5.

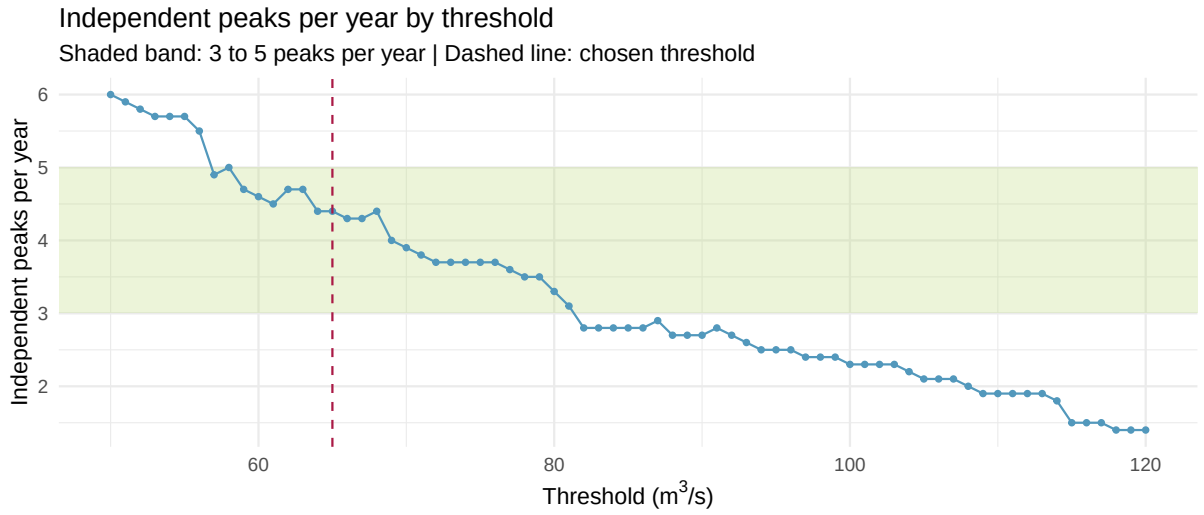


Figure 8: Independent peaks per year at each threshold.

To check which of these is suitable for extreme value modelling, we fit a Generalised Pareto Distribution (GPD) to the excesses of the independent peak flows X above u,

$$P(X - u \leq y \mid X > u) = 1 - \left(1 + \frac{\xi y}{\sigma}\right)^{-1/\xi}, \quad y > 0, \quad 1 + \frac{\xi y}{\sigma} > 0,$$

where $\sigma > 0$ is the scale and $\xi \neq 0$ the shape parameter, with $\xi = 0$ giving an exponential tail as a limiting case. If the GPD holds above u, the mean excess $E[X - u \mid X > u] = (\sigma_0 + \xi u)/(1 - \xi)$ is linear in u (for $\xi < 1$), where σ_0 is the scale parameter at a threshold of 0, and the estimates of ξ and the modified scale $\sigma - \xi u$ stay roughly constant as the threshold increases (Coles, 2001).

[From Figure X, the mean residual life plot is approximately linear above ... m^3/s, and the parameter estimates are stable from ... m^3/s.]

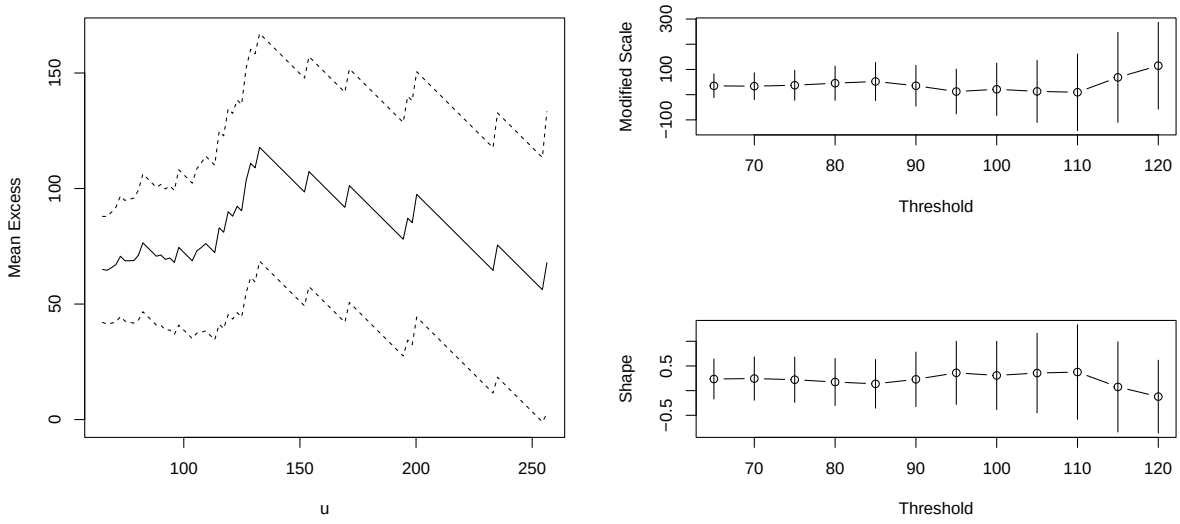


Figure 9: Mean residual life plot (left) and parameter stability plots (right) for the independent peaks at the final threshold.

Since the lecture notes that the threshold may need to change once independence has been applied, we lower it to a final threshold of $u = 65$ m^3/s, [which ...], giving 44 independent events (4.4 per year), with fitted parameters $\hat{\sigma} = 50.34$ (standard error 12.76) and $\hat{\xi} = 0.236$ (standard error 0.207). [The diagnostic plots in Figure 9 show ...]

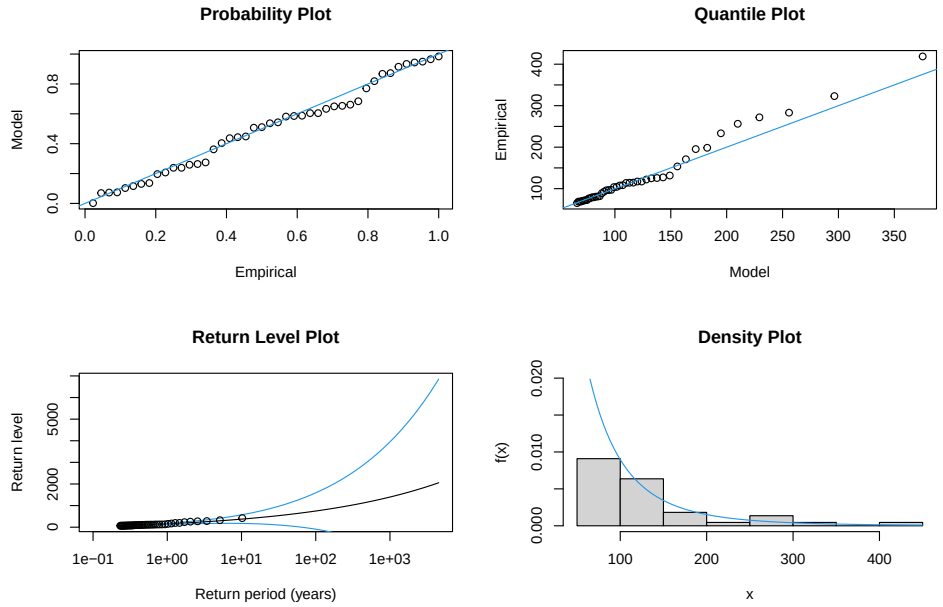


Figure 10: Diagnostic plots for the GPD fitted at the final threshold.

4 Uncertainty Analysis (290 words)

The final threshold of $u = 65\ m^3/s$ identifies 44 independent flood events over the ten water years, across which maximum flow and time to peak both varied considerably (Figures 11 and 12). Maximum flow had a median of 105.83 m^3/s (interquartile range 79.2–128.2 m^3/s), while time to peak had a median of 44.12 hours (interquartile range 25.9–77.9 hours) and ranged from 0.2 to 151.8 hours. This suggests that extreme flood hydrographs cannot be adequately characterised by a single peak magnitude or a fixed time to peak.

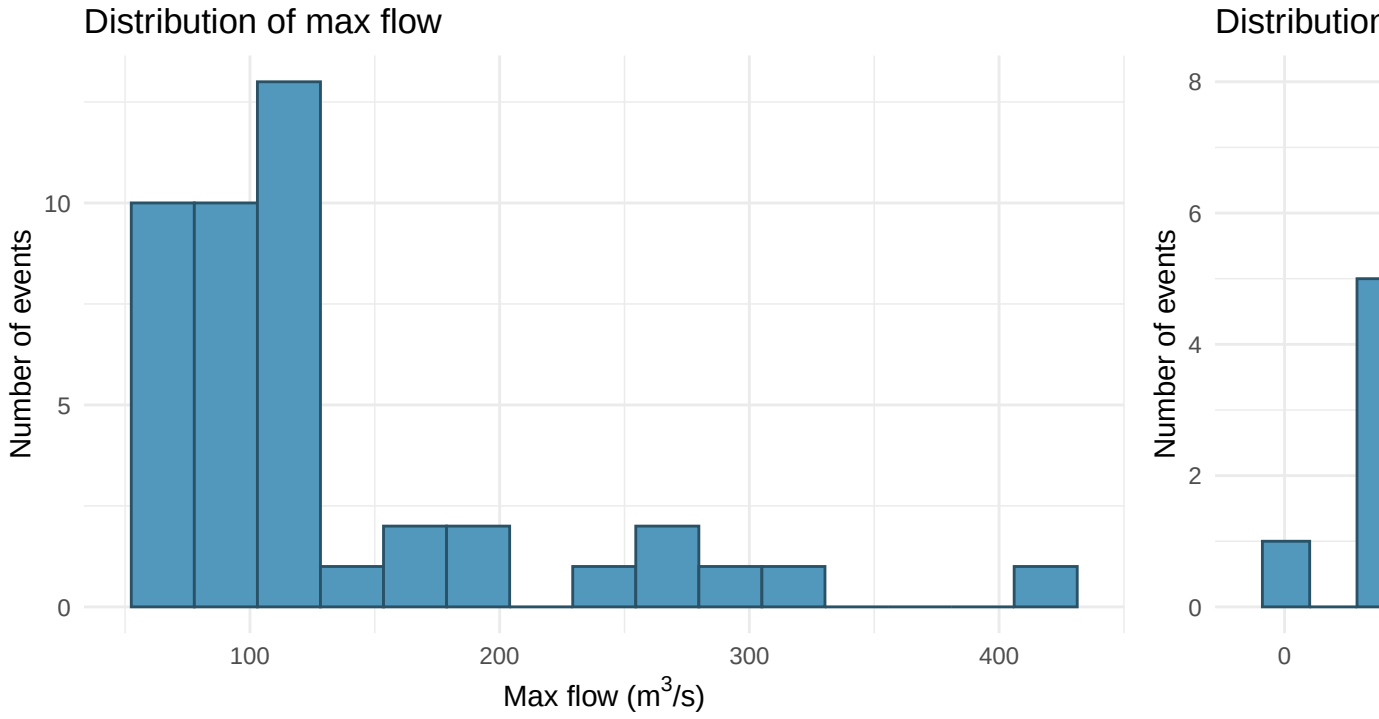


Figure 11: The Distribution of the two parameters

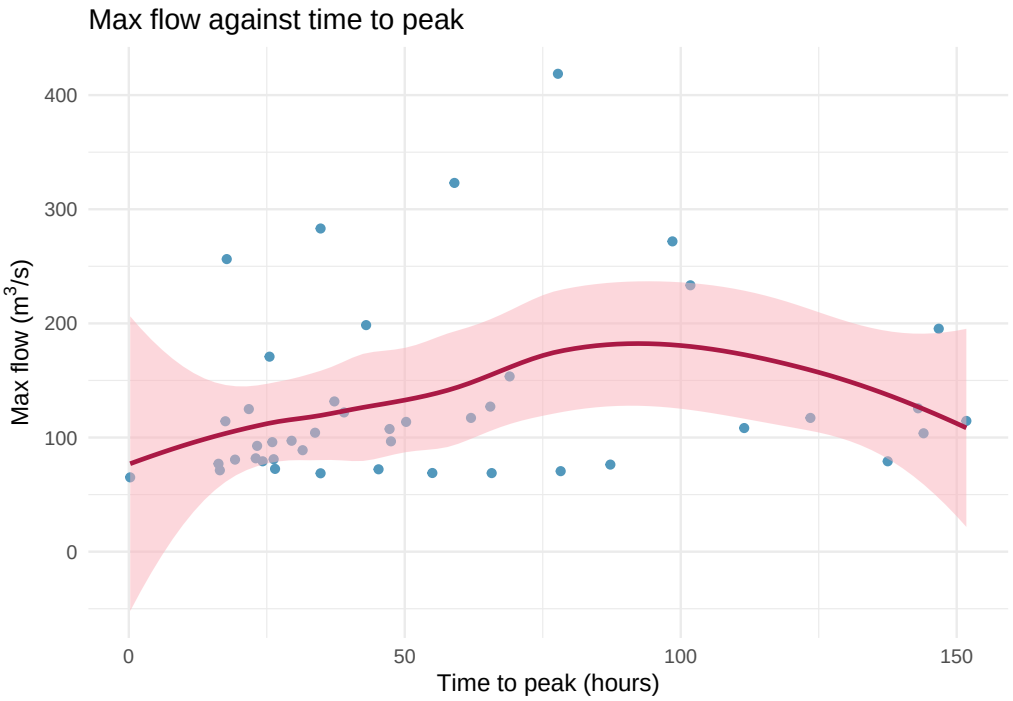


Figure 12: Max flow against time to peak, with a smoothed trend

Since both distributions are skewed and we are interested in any monotonic relationship, we used Spearman's rank correlation, obtaining $\rho = 0.287$ ($p = 0.059$). This indicates a weak positive association, but with insufficient evidence of a monotonic relationship at the 5% significance level, suggesting that larger floods do not necessarily take longer to reach their peak.

Table 2: Spearman's Rank Correlation Between Peak Discharge and Time to Peak

Test	Rho	P-value	S statistic
Spearman's rank correlation	0.287	0.059	10111.57

Autumn events (September–November, $n = 19$) had a median maximum flow of 117.19 m^3/s and time to peak of 59 hours, compared with 108.95 m^3/s and 35.5 hours for winter events (December–February, $n = 18$), suggesting that autumn floods tend to take longer to peak (Table 3, Figure 13). With so few events per season, however, this difference should be treated with caution, and spring (6) and summer (1) had too few events to compare.

Table 3: Summary of Max Flow and Time to Peak for each Season

season	Events	Median max flow	Median time to peak (h)
Winter	18	108.951	35.500
Spring	6	80.812	30.625
Summer	1	88.889	31.500
Autumn	19	117.185	59.000

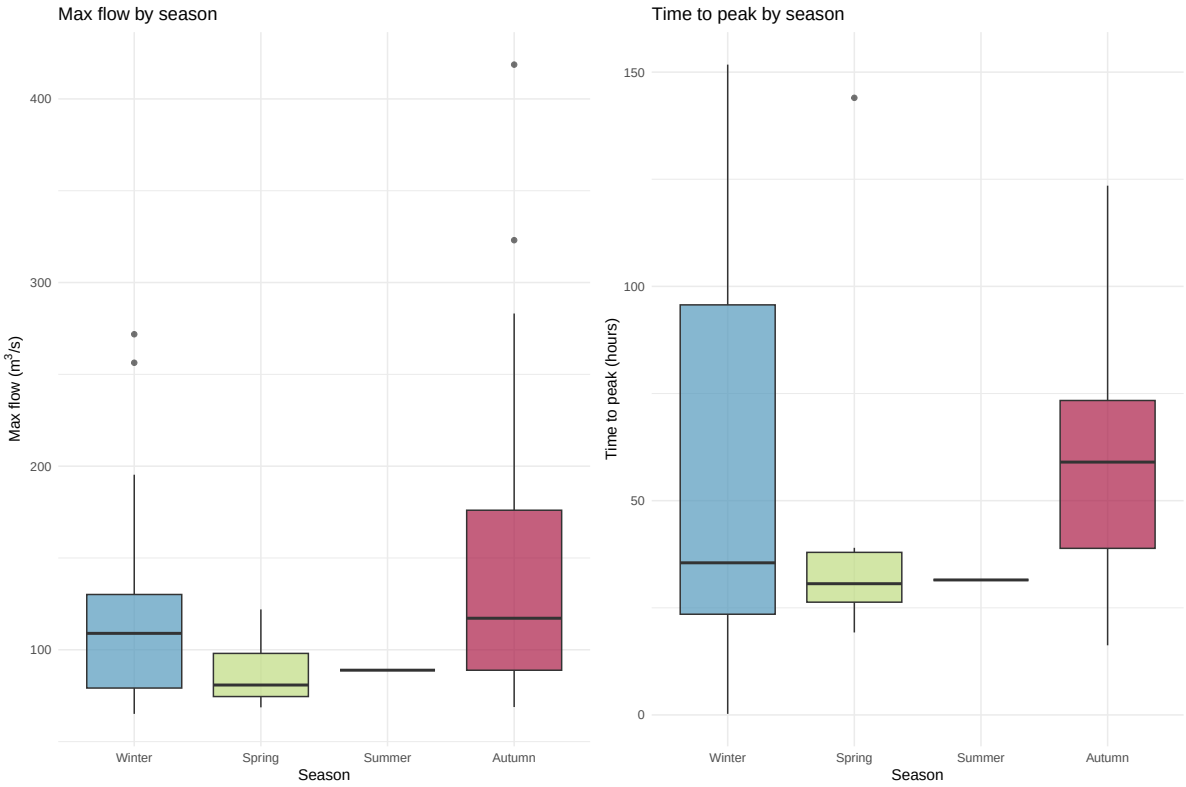


Figure 13: A comparison of the uncertainty in the parameters by season

Table 4: Final Uncertainty Table

threshold	events	Events per Year	Median Max Flow	Median Time to Peak (Hours)	Spearman Rho C
55	57	5.7	81.792	43.000	
60	46	4.6	100.434	44.125	
65	44	4.4	105.834	44.125	
70	39	3.9	108.308	43.000	
75	37	3.7	114.256	47.250	

Repeating the analysis at thresholds of 60-75 m^3/s, median time to peak remained between 43 and 47.25 hours and Spearman's correlation between 0.184 and 0.287 (Table 4), suggesting that the observed variability in time to peak is not simply a consequence of the chosen threshold.

References

Coles, S. (2001) *An Introduction to Statistical Modeling of Extreme Values*. Springer.

Robson, A. and Reed, D. (1999) *Flood Estimation Handbook, Volume 3: Statistical Procedures for Flood Frequency Estimation*. Institute of Hydrology.

Scottish Environment Protection Agency (2026) *SEPA Time Series Data Service*. Available at: https://timeseriesdoc.sepa.org.uk/ (Accessed: 11 October 2026).

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